

Deconstruction



Structuralism offered an alternative to existentialism's idea of freedom to choose how we live our lives. However, the notion of structures, especially those modelled on linguistics, shaping our lives was seen as overly deterministic by some. Both Barthes and Foucault had shown how language could be used to impose ideas and exercise power, and rather than having a clear-cut structure and scientific 'laws', was open to interpretation. A post-structuralist movement evolved, using a method of analysing language, communication and discourse known as deconstruction. This was formalized by Derrida in *Of Grammatology* (1967), which included his

famous declaration that 'there is nothing outside the text', implying that there is no experience of reality, no philosophy, without language. This critical examination of language uncovers not only its deeper meaning, but also its ambiguities. Through deconstruction, post-structuralism uncovered the paradoxical nature of all apparently valid statements about reality or truth, showing them to be based on self-reference and circular reasoning.